STEWART RESIGNS FROM BOARD

Named founding editorial director

BUSINESS inside Sports

CHAVEZ, A'S NEAR DEAL

Long-term contract would keep third baseman in Oakland **SPORTS**

TUESDAY
March 16, 2004

Oakland Tribune

oaklandtribune.com — Serving Oakland for 130 years — 50 cents

Low-cost airlines give lift to airport

■ Growth continues in Oakland for seventh year, but crowds, longer lines could keep trend in check

By Paul T. Rosynsky
STAFF WRITER

OAKLAND — Air travelers continued to flock to Oakland International Airport last year, helping maintain a seven-year growth streak and the mantle of fastest-growing airport in the Bay Area.

Despite ongoing roadway construction, peak-hour congestion and the highest on-airport parking prices in the region, Oakland attracted almost a million more passengers in 2003 than in 2002. Port of Oakland officials say.

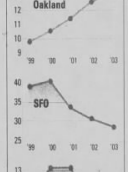
Oakland was the only Bay Area airport to see an increase this year and brought the airport's total number of passengers to 13.5 million, making it the second-busiest airport in the region.

The growth can be attributed to the increased popularity of low-cost airlines such as South-

Please see **GROW**, News 9

Seven-year streak

For the seventh year in a row, Oakland International Airport attracted more passengers than the year before, continuing its status as the fastest-growing airport in the Bay Area.



Source: Airport officials

Sex abuser loses sanctuary

■ Cary Verse leaves after city threatens to evict abbey where he'd stayed for several days; monk says move is political

By Angela Hill and John Geluardi
STAFF WRITER AND CORRESPONDENT

VERSE

OAKLAND — The transitional home at St. Patrick's Abbey in Oakland's Fruitvale district, which had housed released sex offender Cary Verse the past few days, was served Monday afternoon with an eviction notice from city officials.

Verse left the abbey early Monday evening, said the Rev. Donald Weeks, an elderly Benedictine monk who runs the abbey on East 12th Street at 37th Avenue and who had invited Verse to stay there temporarily when he heard of his plight to find housing.

"I have regrets over this," Weeks said late Monday. "I regret the people of Oakland and the City Council of Oakland didn't take better steps to help this man."

Earlier in the day, Weeks lamented that the city threatened to close the abbey down.

"Is this a coincidence?! I don't think so," Weeks said.

"It just happens to be because we've got Mr. Verse here where he has every legal right to be, and people don't like it," Weeks said. "We've been here helping people with the full knowledge of the city since 1999. And all of a sudden we're being forced out. This is like 'Gunsmoke,' where they gang up on somebody to run them out of town."

With angry parents chanting on the street outside the abbey in protest of Verse's proximity to a neighboring school, city officials with a police escort presented Weeks with the "notice to quit" Monday afternoon, citing zoning and code violations.

Oakland city officials say the Verse situation — which drew national media attention during the weekend — merely alerted them to what they call the abbey's illegal use of the property in Oakland's Fruitvale district, an area represented by council President Ignacio De La Fuente.

De La Fuente, who had publicly vowed Friday to make Verse move from

Please see **VERSE**, News 9

CAPITOL PROTEST

NICK LANWERS · Staff photos

THOUSANDS OF community college students marched Monday from Raley Field in Sacramento to the Capitol building to protest fee increases and budget cuts.

Students rally against fee increases

■ Community colleges face second hike in two years under governor's budget plan

By Michelle Maitre
STAFF WRITER

SACRAMENTO — In the middle of the press and confusion of a nearly 10,000-strong student rally against community college budget cuts, Diablo Valley College freshmen Sarah Irwin and Sydney Ruiz rested on a sunny slab of concrete Monday and perfected their rally sign.

"It's no joke. I'm broke," Ruiz wrote in black block letters on a square of neon pink poster board. Irwin surveyed the growing crowd.

AMRAH JOHNSON, 24, of Oakland, speaks Monday in front of the Capitol. Mannequins behind her represent "missing students" who were kept out of colleges this year by budget cuts.

Please see **PROTEST**, News 9

TERROR

Spanish bombing dragnet broadens

■ Authorities close to linking Morocco, Madrid explosions as they probe suspect's ties to al-Qaida

By Andrew Selsky and Nicolas Marmie
ASSOCIATED PRESS

MADRID, Spain — Evidence is mounting that religious extremists linked to al-Qaida were behind the Madrid bombings, and the assault may be tied to a bloody attack in Morocco last year, officials told the Associated Press on Monday.

One of five suspects held by Spanish police in connection with Thursday's attack in Spain had traveled to his home country of Morocco, then left on April 20, 2003 — almost a month before the May 16 attacks in Casablanca that killed 45 people, officials said.

The suspect, Jamal Zougam, also has connections to a key suspect in the Casablanca attacks and possibly to Abu Musab al-Zarqawi, a Moroccan official said, speaking on condition of anonymity.

Al-Zarqawi is a key operative working with Osama bin Laden's terror network who has been blamed in attacks in Jordan, Iraq and elsewhere.

It appears "increasingly

Please see **SPAIN**, News 9

INSIDE: *New prime minister pledges to take Spanish troops out of Iraq.* **News 6**

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Forecast

Mostly sunny
Highs: mid-70s
Lows: low 50s

Details on **Living 8**

Solar system grows with icy find

■ Astronomers say remote planetoid portends more discoveries in next 5 years

By John Noble Wilford
NEW YORK TIMES

Far beyond Pluto, out where the Sun is only a pinpoint of pale light, a frozen world has been found on the dark fringes of the solar system.

Astronomers say it is by far the most distant object known to orbit the Sun and the largest one to be detected since the discovery of Pluto in 1930.

With one discovery, it seems, the solar system has gotten much bigger, glimpses of its outer reaches bringing a sense of reality to what had been a remote frontier of hypothesis. And perhaps it has gotten stranger, too.

"There's absolutely nothing else like it known in the solar system," Dr. Michael Brown, an astronomer at the California Institute of Technology who led the discovery team, said of the newfound object.

But in a telephone news conference on Monday from Pasadena, Brown added, "Our prediction is that there will be many, many more of these objects discovered in the next five years, and some of them will probably be more massive."

The researchers, whose observations were supported by NASA, said the object, referred to as a planetoid, is extremely frigid (minus-400 degrees Fahrenheit) and peculiarly red, probably more so than any other body in the solar system except Mars.

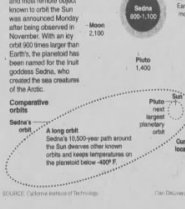
They are not sure why, and also have few ideas of the object's composition. It could be a primordial mix of rock and ice.

Brown's group has proposed naming the object Sedna, after the Inuit goddess who created the sea creatures of the Arctic. For the time being, it is designated as 2003 VB12. The first sighting was made in November at Palomar Observatory, operated by Caltech.

Please see **SEDNA**, News 9

A 'planetoid' past Pluto

Discovery of the coldest and most remote object known to orbit the Sun was announced Monday after being observed in November. With an icy orbit 900 times larger than Earth's, the planetoid has been named for the Inuit goddess Sedna, who created the sea creatures of the Arctic.



SOURCE: California Institute of Technology — Dan DeLorenzo/AP